

SURFACE TREMOR

THE IPL'S STORMING START HAS MADE ITS STAKEHOLDERS UPBEAT BUT THE TRADITIONAL GAME IS IN THE BALANCE AND THE BCCI'S INTERNAL EQUATIONS WILL SOON COME INTO PLAY

■ By Sharda Ugra

Shane Warne didn't like being reminded of the time when he once had an emergency ration of Australian baked beans flown in on a tour of India. Today, he'd rather be known as a true-blue Rajasthan *chhora* or the king of the IPL winners, the Royals. In a flat world, the past is merely an inconvenience to be swatted away as impatiently as Warne did to an Australian reporter's question about them beans.

All he wanted to talk about was the IPL's future, and his place in it. To those watching with scepticism on the outside, particularly in England and Australia, Warne sent out only one consistent message about the IPL, "Don't fight it," he said the day before the final, "Get with it. Get on the bus."

The Indian Premier League is no ordinary bus. After its blockbuster inaugural, it is a bandwagon that will attract on more and more riders. Cricket people, ever alert to the prospect of a

good pay day, have begun calling any and all friends in India. With an annual six-week purge of eyeballs looming, rival television channels have begun strategising and sweating annual purge of eyeballs. Even the most disdainful have sat up at the noise coming out of India. The IPL's future is distinctly green—with profit and envy.

Even if it scarcely seems possible that commentators could shout any louder, the 2009 IPL season should easily out-hype the first. There will be no more auctions but a 'transfer window' which is expected to open some time in February next year to have players switch teams on mutual agreement.

Like Warne, all the 67 overseas players, who participated in the IPL are now its roving emissaries in dressing rooms and slip cordons around the world. They have spoken, in one voice about creating special 'window' for the IPL in the ICC's international calendar so that it does not clash with their national commitments. The ICC has stayed stoic as the tournament has gone on, but statements about how the IPL was bigger than their World Cup, would have amused few, including ICC

56

Indians in the IPL had not represented India in Tests, ODIs or T20s.

ACTION STATIONS: If IPL 2008 was eventful, the 2009 season promises to be even bigger

